recognition of an independent ‘Great Mongolian State’. In return, the Mongols granted the Russians commercial privileges in their country.

To add to the confusion regarding Mongolia’s international status, a Sino-Russian treaty that was concluded shortly afterwards stated that Mongolia was ‘under the suzerainty’ of China, but with internal autonomy.[4] Under yet another treaty, signed by Russia, China, and Mongolia at Kyakhta in Buratiya in Russia on 25 May 1915, Mongolia was forced to recognize that suzerainty and agree not to conclude international treaties with foreign countries.[5]

Before the Treaty of Kyakhta was concluded, Mongolia had tried hard to gain formal recognition of its declaration of independence. A delegation was sent to St Petersburg, but it was prevented by the Russians from seeking further European contacts. An attempt to send a delegation to Tokyo was aborted when the Japanese consul in Harbin, Manchuria, refused to provide any assistance to the Mongols.

The only diplomatic success that the Mongols had was with their religious brethren in Tibet. On 11 January 1913 (29 December 1912, according to the Russian calendar), the Treaty of Friendship and Alliance was signed at Urga, now Ulaanbaatar, between Mongolia and Tibet. Mongolia was represented by its foreign minister, Da Lama Rabdan, and the commander-in-chief of the armed forces, Manlaibaatar Damdinsüren. Rabdan signed the agreement with Agvan Dorzhiev as a representative of Tibet’s Dalai Lama. But the problem was that Dorzhiev hailed from Buryatia, a Mongol-speaking part of eastern Siberia, and was thus technically a Russian citizen. The validity of the treaty, therefore, has been questioned.[6]

Tibet also declared its independence during the turbulent first years of the Republic of China—although there is some confusion as to when, exactly, that declaration was made. In early 1910, the Qing had sent an expeditionary force to invade Tibet in a last attempt to assert authority over the territories they claimed to be within the boundaries of their empire. The Chinese marched into the Tibetan capital, Lhasa, on 12 February 1910 and deposed the thirteenth Dalai Lama. He fled to India and was invited to Kolkata by the then Viceroy, Lord Minto.

The Dalai Lama’s flight to India helped restore his relations with Britain: Britain had, in December 1903, sent a force led by Francis